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Paved with good intentions: role of situational and dispositional influences on employees' unethical pro-organizational behavior

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Abstract

Purpose – The rise in the instances of ethical scandals in recent times has brought to light the hitherto ignored phenomenon of unethical proorganizational behavior (UPB) by employees. Drawing upon the social exchange theory, this study aims to examine the role of perceived organizational support (POS) and organizational identification on UPB. The research also investigated the moderating role of core self-evaluation (CSE) and positive reciprocity beliefs.

Design/methodology/approach – The hypotheses were tested with three-wave survey data collected from 306 executives from India. Data was analyzed using mediation and moderated mediation analyses on PROCESS v 3.0 macro.

Findings – Results showed that organizational identification mediated the relationship between POS and UPB. Further, CSE and positive reciprocity beliefs were seen to moderate the mediated relationship providing support for the moderated mediation framework.

Practical implications – The study highlights the importance of clear code of ethics, communication of ethical guidelines and ethical behavior of the managers as some of the ways to reduce the menace of UPB. Further, managers should be more vigilant toward the employees low on CSE and high on positive reciprocity beliefs as they are more prone to engage in UPB given their identification with the organization.

Originality/value – To the best of the authors' knowledge, this is the first study to investigate the mediating role of organizational identification in the relationship between POS and UPB. Further, to the best of the authors' knowledge, no previous study has explored the moderating role of CSE and positive reciprocity beliefs in the aforesaid mediation.

Keywords Perceived organizational support, Organizational identification, Unethical proorganizational behavior, Core self-evaluation, Positive reciprocity beliefs

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

Although unethical behavior at the workplace is an age-old problem, most of the research in behavioral ethics has focused on the behaviors that are undertaken for self-benefit or to retaliate against the employing organization (Seuntjens *et al.*, 2019; Thau *et al.*, 2015).

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However, recent studies have suggested that people may also engage in unethical behaviors to benefit their organization (Dennerlein and Kirkman, 2022; Lee *et al.*, 2022; Wang *et al.*, 2021; Yan *et al.*, 2021; Zhang, 2020). This type of behavior, known as unethical proorganizational behavior (UPB), has brought into focus possible blind spots in the organizations where some behaviors which clearly violate ethical guidelines and codes may be ignored or even encouraged to achieve short-term objectives, often at the risk of long-term damage (Miao *et al.*, 2020; Umphress *et al.*, 2010). Thus, a nuanced understanding of the situational and dispositional factors which lead to the UPB can provide valuable insights into how to prevent the employees from engaging in this kind of behavior.

In their theoretical model, Umphress and Bingham (2011) proposed that perceived organizational support (POS) enhances the employees' engagement in UPB due to the norms of social exchange or reciprocity. It was also anticipated in their study that enhanced organizational identification may lead to UPB through the process of neutralization. Further, many researchers have also shown that POS acts as an antecedent to organizational identification (Chhabra, 2020; Zagenczyk *et al.*, 2021). Combining these two perspectives and using the framework of social exchange theory (SET), the present study aims to delineate the process through which POS leads to UPB. In doing so, we aim to provide support for the contention that constructs like POS and organizational identification, which are generally considered beneficial for the organizational functioning may lead to UPB.

Further, previous studies have shown the strength of association between organizational identification and UPB is dependent on moderating variables like message framing (Alniacik *et al.*, 2022), interorganization competition (Chen *et al.*, 2016) and disposition toward ethical/unethical behavior (Effelsberg *et al.*, 2014). To expand this body of research, it would be meaningful to examine the impact of other personality variables which may impact employees' engagement in UPB when their organizational identification is high. One such important dispositional factor is core self-evaluation (CSE) which refers to "fundamental premises that individuals hold about themselves and their functioning in the world" (Judge *et al.*, 1998a, 1998b, p. 161). Since individuals high on CSE hold a stable positive view about themselves, their behavior may be less influenced by situational factors. Therefore, it is suggested that CSE acts as a moderator in the relationship between organizational identification and UPB. Apart from CSE, the study also examines the moderating effect of positive reciprocity beliefs in the association between organizational identification and UPB.

In brief, this study investigates the relationship between POS and UPB, focusing on the mediating role of organizational identification and moderating role of CSE and positive reciprocity beliefs (Figure 1). In doing so, it makes several contributions to the existing literature. First, it provides convincing evidence regarding the negative effects of the constructs like POS that are considered beneficial for organizational functioning. Second, this research throws light on the mediating mechanism of the aforementioned relationship through organizational identification which advances our awareness of the identification literature. Third, the study examines the moderating role CSE and positive reciprocity beliefs in the aforesaid relationship. Exploring the antecedents and boundary conditions of UPB via this study aims to provide a nuanced insights regarding the reasons for employees' engagement in UPB, thus broadening the scope of research related to unethical behavior.

Theoretical framework and hypotheses development

Social exchange theory

To understand workplace behaviors, the time-tested SET is one of the most significant conceptual framework (Blau, 1964; Thibaut and Kelley, 1959). The theory explains workplace interactions in terms of interdependent social exchanges generating obligations

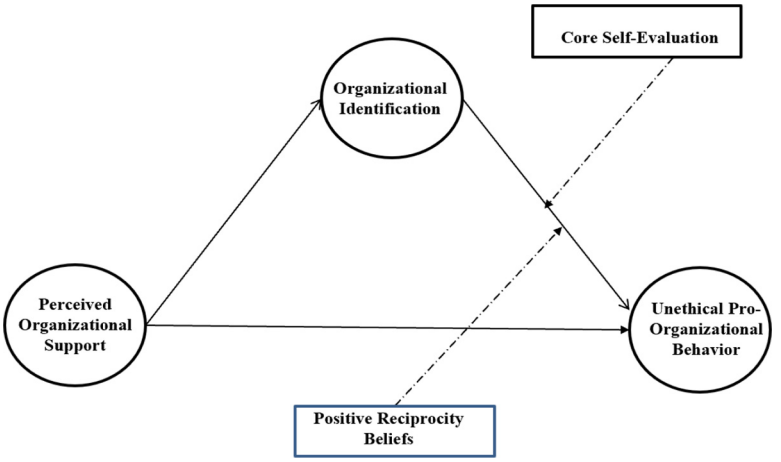


Figure 1.
Proposed conceptual model

between actors based on certain rules or norms of reciprocity. Extending this logic to the organizational context, employees do not just perform to fulfil organizational duties but also to reciprocate the positive or negative treatment met out by employers. Although the exchange is voluntary, failure to reciprocate may entail sanctions like distrust, opprobrium or denial of future benefits, whereas positive reciprocation may lead to a self-perpetuating exchange of benefits. Application of SET conceptual framework implies that when employees believe that the organization values their contribution, they feel obligated to repay by exhibiting behaviors that support organizational functioning.

Perceived organizational support and unethical proorganisational behavior

UPB refers to "actions that are intended to promote the effective functioning of the organization or its members and violate core societal values, morals, laws, or standards of proper conduct" (Umphress and Bingham, 2011, p. 622). This may include acts of commission (e.g. exaggerating the organization's achievements) or omission (e.g. hiding the negative information about the organization from customers and other external stakeholders). UPB expands the scope of research in the domain of business ethics by focusing attention on the ethical challenges caused by the motives, values and behaviors which are otherwise considered positive for the effective functioning of the organization.

POS refers to the employees' beliefs regarding the degree to which the organization cares about their well-being and values their contributions (Eisenberger *et al.*, 1986). Extant research has found that POS is positively associated with many employee- and organization-related outcomes like work engagement, job performance, job satisfaction, job crafting and decreased absenteeism, job stress and employee turnover (Akgunduz and Sanli, 2017; Kurtessis *et al.*, 2017).

Research has shown that experience of positive social exchange by the employees increases their incidence of engaging in UPB. For example, high performance work systems (Xu and Lv, 2018), job satisfaction (Zhang, 2020), high inducement employee-organization relationships (Wang *et al.*, 2019) and leader-member exchange (Bryant and Merritt, 2021) have been positively associated with UPB. The employees may view engaging in these kinds of behaviors like selling unsafe products or lying to the customers, as their idea of

reciprocating the positive treatment received from the organization. Based on the above rationale, the following hypothesis is therefore proposed:

H1. POS is positively related to UPB.

Perceived organizational support and organizational identification

Organizational identification refers to "the perception of oneness or belongingness with the organization" (Ashforth *et al.*, 2008; Liu *et al.*, 2011). Employees with strong organizational identification are more prone to adhere to and behave according to the norms and values of the organization (Ashforth and Mael, 1989), and it enables individuals to internalize organization's failures and successes as their own.

Applying insights from SET, it has been shown that employee confidence is enhanced if trust and appreciation is shown toward them by the organization (Cropanzano and Mitchell, 2005). The show of inclusiveness and trust by the management fosters a sense of belongingness, and the employee feels valued and respected. This inculcates belongingness toward the organization and a centrality to his place in the scheme of things, providing a strong incentive toward such a collective organizational identity.

This assertion has been supported in a study by Wiesenfeld *et al.* (2001), which demonstrated that perception of social support was positively associated to organizational identification among virtual workers. Another study found that effect of leader member exchange (LMX) on organizational identification was mediated by POS (Sluss *et al.*, 2008). Similarly, research by Edwards (2009) found that POS mediated the relationship between human resource (HR) environment and organizational identification, whereas in a different study (Eisenberger *et al.*, 2001), organizational identification acted as a mediator between POS and turnover intention. Based on the argument given above, we propose the following hypothesis:

H2. POS is positively related to organizational identification.

Organizational identification and unethical proorganisational behavior

Although organizational identification is a considered as a positive construct, there is concern regarding the possible downsides of this construct (Conroy *et al.*, 2017). According to Dukerich *et al.* (1998), high levels of identification may lead to a state of "over-identification" in which the needs of employees are based completely on their membership with the organization. In this state of "over-identification" the feelings of disagreement with the organization may be suppressed by the individual, who may then be prone to support unethical behaviors of the organization. Any dissonance which an employee may experience due to such unethical behavior may be rationalized through a process known as neutralization (Sykes and Matza, 1957). It has been posited that employees exhibiting higher organizational identification may be more prone to go all out to counter perceived threats to their organization's reputation and well-being, especially in the face of challenges like competition from rivals, legal cases and regulatory scrutiny (Balliet *et al.*, 2014; Leavitt and Sluss, 2015). Seen in this context, such employees having higher organizational identification have a need for cohesion with the in-group and are more likely to push moral boundaries to justify proorganizational behaviors.

The above claims can be substantiated by the recent researchers where positive relationship was found between organizational identification and UPB (Chen *et al.*, 2016;

Effelsberg *et al.*, 2014; Kong, 2016). To further investigate this relationship, we propose the following hypothesis:

H3. Organizational identification is positively related to UPB.

Mediating role of organizational identification

On one hand, it is well established that POS leads to organizational identification; on the other, evidence linking organizational identification to UPB is quite strong. Therefore, it is not surprising that the most glaring illustrations of such unethical behaviors are often seen in organizations which lay greater emphasis on organizational identification to the exclusion of individual's own identity. The cases of abuse of authority by police or armed forces to counter the perceived threats to their institutions are an indicator of how much organizational identification can affect the outlook and behaviors of the members of the group. Specifically, when employees realize that the organization and leaders are supportive, they are likely to identify with the organization and take responsibility for its success and failure (Zhao *et al.*, 2019). Their own values, ethics and morals become subservient to the interests of the organization. Therefore, the likelihood of these employees to engage in unethical behaviors that benefit the organization increases.

Researchers have claimed that POS enhances organizational membership which contributes to individuals acting out to support the organization. Such contention has found support in previous studies (Edwards and Peccei, 2010; Marique *et al.*, 2013; Shen *et al.*, 2014) which show that POS predicts organizational identification, which, in turn, leads to positive organizational outcomes like organizational involvement, organizational citizenship behaviour (OCB) and job performance. Taking a cue from the aforementioned reasoning and the findings, it is reasonable to infer that the heightened level of identification which comes from perception of organizational support may result in the increased willingness to diverge from the ethical norms for the benefit of the organization. It can thus be argued cogently that organizational identification acts as a mediator in the relationship between POS and UPB. Hence it is proposed that:

H4. Organizational identification mediates the relationship between POS and UPB.

Moderating role of core self-evaluation

Beu and Buckley (2001) showed that ethical intents and subsequent behaviors of people are determined to a large extent by personality characteristics. Therefore, although it has been proposed that employees having greater organizational identification are more prone to engage in UPB, it may not impact all such employees uniformly. In an attempt to comprehend how people evaluate themselves, Judge *et al.* (1998a, 1998b) introduced the broad construct of CSE comprising of four core traits, namely, self-esteem, self-efficacy, *locus* of control and emotional stability. People high on CSE are more in control of themselves which helps them to successfully cope with the restrictions imposed by the environment and pursue goals which are intrinsically motivating (Johnson *et al.*, 2008; Kim *et al.*, 2015).

According to Judge and Kammeyer-Mueller (2011), individuals having high CSE are likely to behave more ethically because morality becomes internalized as an integral part of their personality. They have a positive self-view, and hence they are expected to exhibit behaviors in line with their self-view. Therefore, these people are likely to maintain high ethical standards and are not expected to engage in behavior which would be contrary to

their existing self-view. These results have been supported by Ahn *et al.* (2018), who confirmed a positive association between leaders' CSE and ethical leadership.

Additionally, people exhibiting high CSE have an internal *locus* of control, i.e. their behavior is less impacted by environmental factors and is more a function of their conviction. Research has shown a link between internal *locus* of control and moral behavior like resistance to cheating and social pressure to conform (Lefcourt, 1982). Internals use self-regulatory mechanisms to keep focus on performance without becoming unduly perturbed by external cues, and their internal focus keeps them on an even keel without getting tempted to try shortcuts, which often are of questionable ethicality. Therefore, despite being high on organizational identification, there is little likelihood of their engaging in UPB as such behavior goes against their basic personality. However, people low on CSE who identify with the organization may go out of the way to prove their loyalty toward the organization, even at the expense of engaging in unethical behaviors. Hence it is proposed that:

H5. CSE moderates the relationship between organizational identification and UPB such that the positive relationship is weaker for employees high on CSE compared to those low on CSE.

As has been hypothesized, organizational identification transfers the influence of POS to UPB, and CSE moderates this association between organizational identification and UPB. Based on the notion that organizational identification is more positively linked to UPB when CSE is low, we further propose that the indirect effect of POS on UPB via organizational identification is stronger for the employees who are low on CSE compared to those high on CSE. Hence it is proposed:

H6. CSE moderates the indirect effect of POS on UPB through organizational identification such that the mediated relationship is stronger for employees low on CSE.

Moderating role of positive reciprocity beliefs

As has been stated earlier, SET forms the basis of all sound interpersonal relations, which are established by resource exchange between two partners (Blau, 1964; Gouldner, 1960). However, people differ in the degree to which they return the favorable treatment received from the exchange partner (Cropanzano and Mitchell, 2005). This term known as positive reciprocity beliefs is a deep-rooted obligation for reciprocity on the part of an individual and is an important psychological process connecting give and take among exchange partners (Eisenberger *et al.*, 2001). Positive reciprocators feel greater commitment to reciprocate the favorable behavior of their exchange allies, and their behavior is focused on maximizing the gains and benefits of their exchange partners. They tend to "maintain account" of the reciprocations performed by the exchange partner so as to balance the transaction of resources (Ackermann *et al.*, 2016). They have higher altruistic spirits (Zou *et al.*, 2015) and are more sensitive to positive interpersonal interaction. When they receive timely and significant support from others, the psychological and behavioral aspects of their reactions (e.g. organizational identification and organizational citizenship behavior) are likely to be more intense since they maintain high quality exchange with others (Cheng *et al.*, 2022; Chhabra, 2020).

Going by the rationale given above, it can be expected that employees having strong positive reciprocity beliefs are more likely to exhibit UPB when their identification with the using organization is high. Therefore, we propose the following hypothesis:

H7. Positive reciprocity beliefs moderate the relationship between organizational identification and UPB such that the strength of positive relationship is stronger for employees high for positive reciprocity beliefs compared to those who are low.

Based on the above rationale, it seems plausible that the indirect effect of POS on UPB via organizational identification is expected to be greater for the employees high on positive reciprocity beliefs compared to the ones who are low. Hence it is proposed:

H8. Positive reciprocity beliefs moderate the indirect effect of POS on UPB through organizational identification such that the mediated effect is stronger for individuals high on positive reciprocity beliefs.

Research methodology

Sample and procedure

The participants for this research were the executives working in different Indian organizations who were the alumni of a reputed business school in India. Their contact details were obtained from the alumni database of the business school and approximately 1,000 alumni, chosen randomly from the database, were sent an invitation to participate in the survey. The participation in the survey was voluntary, and the invitees were appraised about the academic purpose of the research ensuring complete confidentiality of their responses. A three-wave research design was used to ensure the temporal separation of the measurement of independent variable and demographic information (T1: POS and control variables), mediator and moderators (T2: organizational identification, CSE and positive reciprocity beliefs) and outcome variable (T3: UPB). The time lag between each point of measurement was two weeks. The purpose to have a time lagged design was to mitigate respondent fatigue and reduce common method variance. The alumni who agreed to participate in the study were sent a questionnaire to gauge their POS and demographic variables at T1. Those who responded in T1 were asked to rate their organizational identification, CSE and positive reciprocity beliefs in T2, which was after two weeks. Participants who completed the questionnaire in T2 were asked to complete UPB questionnaire in T3, which was after two weeks from T2. In all, 625 respondents agreed to participate in the study leading to the response rate of 62.5%. Of these 625 respondents, 507 filled the questionnaire in T1, resulting in the response rate of 50.7%. These 507 participants were sent a questionnaire comprising of mediators and moderators and 403 completed the questionnaire in T2 leading to the response rate of 40.3%. Finally, 306 usable questionnaires were received in T3 resulting in the overall response rate of 30.6%. The final sample comprised of the executives working in various types of organizations in different sectors such as education, banking and finance, information technology, manufacturing, FMCG and government with 53 respondents from sectors other than those listed above. The age of the respondents ranged from 23 to 58 years (mean age 32.24 years and SD 7.38), 208 of them were males and 98 were females. In total, 93.5% of the respondents had been working with their current organization for less than nine years. Since the response rate was lower between T1 and T3, the demographic characteristics of those who fully responded, partially responded and did not respond were compared. The responding, partially responding and nonresponding participants at each stage did not differ with respect to gender, age and tenure with the organization. Hence the problem of systematic nonresponse bias was ruled out.

Research instruments

All the survey items were presented in English, and the responses to all the items ranged from strongly disagree (1) to strongly agree (5).

POS (T1): This was measured using an eight-item scale by Eisenberger *et al.* (1997). A sample item of the scale was "My organization strongly considers my goals and values."

Organizational identification (T2): To assess organizational identification, a six-item scale from Mael and Ashforth (1992) was used. The sample item of this scale is "When someone criticizes my organization, it feels like a personal insult."

Positive reciprocity beliefs (T2): A 10-item measure by Eisenberger *et al.* (2004) was used to assess positive reciprocity beliefs. The sample item contained, "If someone does me a favor, I feel obligated to repay them in some way."

CSE (T2): This was assessed using a measure created by Judge *et al.* (2003). It consists of 12 items assessing the traits of self-esteem (e.g. "Overall I am satisfied with myself"), generalized self-efficacy (e.g. "When I try, I generally succeed"), neuroticism (e.g. "Sometimes I feel depressed") and *locus* of control (e.g. "I determine what will happen in my life"). Six questions were reverse-coded.

UPB (T3): This was measured with six-item scale developed by Umphress *et al.* (2010). The sample item included, "If needed, I would conceal information from the public that could be damaging to my organization."

Control variables (T1): Prior research in the field of ethics has revealed that the extent to which people engage in unethical behavior may be influenced by demographic variables (Erdogan and Liden, 2002). Therefore, the effect of demographic characteristics was controlled for all regression analysis. Control variables in this research were gender, age and tenure with the organization. Gender was evaluated using a dichotomous scale: male (1) and female (2). Continuous scale was used to gauge age and tenure which were in years.

Results and analysis

Confirmatory factory analysis

To assess the model fit, confirmatory factory analysis was performed and the proposed model having five latent factors (i.e. POS, organizational identification, CSE, positive reciprocity beliefs and UPB) was compared with alternative models. All the indicators were seen to have statistically significant loadings ($p < 0.001$) on their corresponding constructs. The proposed five factor model showed a good fit: χ^2 = 1,334.85; df = 809; χ^2/df = 1.65; CFI = 0.96; IFI = 0.96; RMSEA = 0.05 (Arbuckle, 1997; Browne and Cudeck, 1993). The base model exhibited a significantly better fit than other parsimonious models. The alternative models were a four-factor model with CSE and positive reciprocity beliefs loaded on one factor (χ^2 = 2,349.57; df = 813; χ^2/df = 2.89; CFI = 0.87; IFI = 0.87; RMSEA = 0.09); a three-factor model with CSE, positive reciprocity beliefs and UPB loaded on one factor (χ^2 = 2,636.79; df = 817; χ^2/df = 3.23; CFI = 0.56; IFI = 0.57; RMSEA = 0.097); a two-factor model with organizational identification, CSE, positive reciprocity beliefs and UPB loaded on one factor (χ^2 = 3,331.36; df = 819; χ^2/df = 4.07; CFI = 0.39; IFI = 0.41; RMSEA = 0.17); and a one-factor model with all variables loaded on a single factor (χ^2 = 4,354.23; df = 820; χ^2/df = 5.3; CFI = 0.15; IFI = 0.17; RMSEA = 0.19). Thus, the results provide support to the notion that the key measures used in the study were unique in nature.

Test of common method bias

Further, since the data was collected using self-report measures from the same source, threat of common method bias could not be ruled out. Harman's single-factor test was used to statistically assess the impact of common method bias. The total variance explained by a

single factor was just 22.45, which is less than 50%. Further, since the 1-factor model did not fit well with the data (χ^2 = 4,354.23; df = 820; χ^2/df = 5.3; CFI = 0.15; IFI = 0.17; RMSEA = 0.19) the possibility of common method variance in the study was ruled out.

Reliability and convergent validity

Table 1 shows the reliability and convergent validity. As can be seen from the table, good internal consistency was demonstrated by all scales as all Cronbach alpha estimates exceeded 0.70 threshold (Nunnally, 1978). All factor loadings were more than 0.60 and average variance extracted (AVE) values were above 0.50 which indicates good convergent validity (Hair *et al.*, 2018).

We used the criteria given by Fornell and Larcker (1981) for establishing the discriminant validity. As can be seen from Table 2, square roots of AVE (italic values given in diagonal) are greater than intervariable correlations confirming that the variables exhibit good discriminant validity.

Hypotheses testing

Tests for direct and indirect impact (H1–H4). Based on the suggestions given by Preacher *et al.* (2007) and Hayes (2013), the main hypotheses related to mediation were tested using PROCESS macro for SPSS (Model 4) developed by Hayes (2013). In the current study, the 95% confidence interval of the indirect effects was achieved with 5,000 bootstrap resamples (Preacher and Hayes, 2008). The findings of the analysis can be seen in Table 3 and are also displayed in Figure 2. In support for *H1*, it was noticed that POS was positively and significantly related to UPB (B = 0.12, t = 2.74, $p < 0.01$). It was also found that POS was positively related to organizational identification (B = 0.30, t = 8.21, $p < 0.01$) supporting *H2* and organizational identification was positively related to UPB (B = 0.23, t = 3.53, $p < 0.01$) supporting *H3*.

Further, the findings of the mediation analysis established the mediating role of organizational identification in the relationship between POS and UPB (B = 0.07; CI = 0.03 to 0.12). The results also suggested that the direct effect of POS on UPB became nonsignificant (B = 0.05, t = 1.01, p = 0.31) when controlling for organizational identification, thus suggesting full mediation and supporting *H4*.

Test of moderated-mediation models. To study the fully specified moderated mediation models, the proposed moderators, i.e. CSE and positive reciprocity beliefs were incorporated into the model, one at a time. For this purpose, PROCESS macro (Model 14) created by Hayes (2013) was used. This technique uses bootstrapping procedures with 95% confidence intervals providing results for moderation and conditional indirect effects between the independent and the dependent variable through the mediator at different levels of moderator (one SD above and below the mean of the moderator).

Moderating role of core self-evaluation (H5–H6). As is evident from Table 4, CSE acts as a moderator the relationship between organizational identification and UPB since the interaction between organizational identification and CSE on UPB was found to be significant (B = −0.04, t = −2.61, $p < 0.01$). To enable the interpretation of the interaction terms, the conditional slopes were plotted at low, medium and high levels of CSE (−1 SD, mean and +1 SD). As is evident from Table 4 and Figure 3, the relationship between organizational identification and UPB for executives who are low on CSE is a positive and significant (B = 0.45, t = 3.36, $p < 0.01$) which becomes negative and nonsignificant for the employees high on CSE (B = −0.01, t = −0.09, *ns*). These results support *H5*.

To test moderated mediation, the conditional indirect effects of POS on UPB through organizational identification were examined at different levels of CSE (−1 SD, mean and +1

Constructs and scale items	Factor loadings	Cronbach's alpha (α)	Composite reliability (CR)	Average variance extracted (AVE)
Core self-evaluation				
I am confident that I get the success I deserve in life	0.73			
Sometimes I feel depressed	0.79			
When I try, I generally succeed	0.66			
Sometimes when I fail, I feel worthless	0.72			
I complete tasks successfully	0.75			
Sometimes, I do not feel in control of my work	0.68	0.90	0.91	0.51
Overall, I am satisfied with myself	0.72			
I am filled with doubts about my competence	0.69			
I determine what will happen in my life	0.61			
I do not feel in control of my success in my career	0.71			
I am capable of coping with most of my problems	0.77			
There are times when things look pretty hopeless to me	0.72			
Positive reciprocity beliefs				
If someone does me a favor, I feel obligated to repay them in some way	0.66			
If someone does something for me, I feel required to do something for them	0.71			
If someone gives me a gift, I feel obligated to get them a gift	0.75			
I always repay someone who has done me a favor	0.76			
I feel uncomfortable when someone does me a favor which I know I won't be able to return	0.84	0.91	0.91	0.52
If someone sends me a card on my birthday, I feel required to do the same	0.60			
When someone does something for me, I often find myself thinking about what I have done for them	0.79			
If someone says something pleasant to me, I feel I should also say something pleasant back	0.69			
I usually do not forget if I owe someone a favor, or if someone owes me a favor	0.64			
If someone treats me well, I should treat that person well in return	0.73			
Perceived organizational support				
My organization cares about my opinions	0.91			
My organization really cares about my well-being	0.81			
My organization strongly considers my goals and values	0.80			
Help is available from my organization when I have a problem	0.71	0.92	0.92	0.59
My organization will forgive an honest mistake on my part	0.60			
My organization is willing to help me if I need special favor	0.65			

Table 1. Measurement model reliability and validity

(*continued*)

Constructs and scale items	Factor loadings	Cronbach's alpha (α)	Composite reliability (CR)	Average variance extracted (AVE)
My organization takes pride in my accomplishments	0.86			
My organization shows high concern for me	0.76			
Unethical proorganizational behavior				
If it would help my organization, I would misrepresent the truth to make it look good	0.86			
If it would help my organization, I would exaggerate the truth about its services to the customers	0.60			
If it would benefit my organization, I would withhold negative information about its products and services from customers	0.74	0.87	0.88	0.56
If my organization needed me to, I would withhold issuing a refund to a customer which is accidently overcharged	0.68			
If needed, I would conceal information from the public that could be damaging to my organization	0.71			
If my organization needed me to, I would give a good recommendation to an incompetent employee in the hope that the person leaves the organization	0.86			
Organizational identification				
When someone criticizes my organization, it feels like a personal insult	0.69			
I am very interested in what others think about my organization	0.61	0.85	0.86	0.51
When I talk about my company, I usually say "we" rather than "they"	0.66			
My organization's successes are my successes	0.72			
When someone praises my organization, it feels like a personal compliment	0.84			
If a story in the media criticized my organization, I would feel embarrassed	0.75			

Table 1.

Variables	POS	OID	UPB	PRB	CSE
POS	*0.77*				
OID	0.43	*0.71*			
UPB	0.16	0.22	*0.74*		
PRB	0.08	0.29	0.17	*0.72*	
CSE	0.28	0.20	−0.19	−0.04	*0.71*

Notes: PRB: positive reciprocity beliefs, OID: organizational identification

Table 2.
Discriminant validity

SD). The results in Table 4 suggest that the conditional indirect effect was significantly distinct at mean (*indirect effect* = 0.082, 95% CI [0.043, 0.127]). The indirect effect becomes more at one standard deviation below (−1 SD) the mean (*indirect effect* = 0.11, 95% CI [0.010, 0.102]) and less at one standard deviation above (+1 SD) the mean (*indirect effect* = 0.053, 95% CI [0.067, 0.126]). These outcomes are in line with *H6* and provide support for the moderated mediation among the variables when CSE is a moderator.

Moderating role of positive reciprocity beliefs (H7–H8). As can be seen from Table 5, positive reciprocity beliefs moderate the relationship between organizational identification and UPB ($B = 0.02$, $t = 2.29$, $p < 0.05$). Table 5 and Figure 4 shows that the relationship between organizational identification and UPB for executives who are high on positive reciprocity beliefs is a positive and significant ($B = 0.43$, $t = 4.24$, $p < 0.01$) which becomes nonsignificant for the executives low on positive reciprocity beliefs ($B = 0.16$, $t = 1.72$, *ns*). These results lend full support to *H7*.

To check for the full moderated mediation, the conditional indirect effects of POS on UPB through organizational identification were examined at different levels of positive reciprocity beliefs (−1 SD, mean and +1 SD). The results in Table 5 imply that the conditional indirect effect was significantly distinct at mean (*indirect effect* = 0.096, 95% CI

Table 3.
Hypotheses testing for direct and indirect impact

Impact	B	SE	T	Sig. level	Outcome
POS → UPB	0.12	0.04	2.74	*P < 0.01*	*H1* supported
POS → OID	0.30	0.04	8.21	*P < 0.01*	*H2* supported
OID → UPB	0.23	0.07	3.53	*P < 0.01*	*H3* supported
Indirect effect of POS on UPB					
	Effect	***SE***	***LL 95% CI***	***UL 95% CI***	Outcome
POS → OID → UPB	0.07	0.02	0.03	0.12	*H4* supported

Notes: B: unstandardized regression coefficients; SE: standard error; LL: lower limit, CI: confidence interval, UL: upper limit (OID: organizational identification)

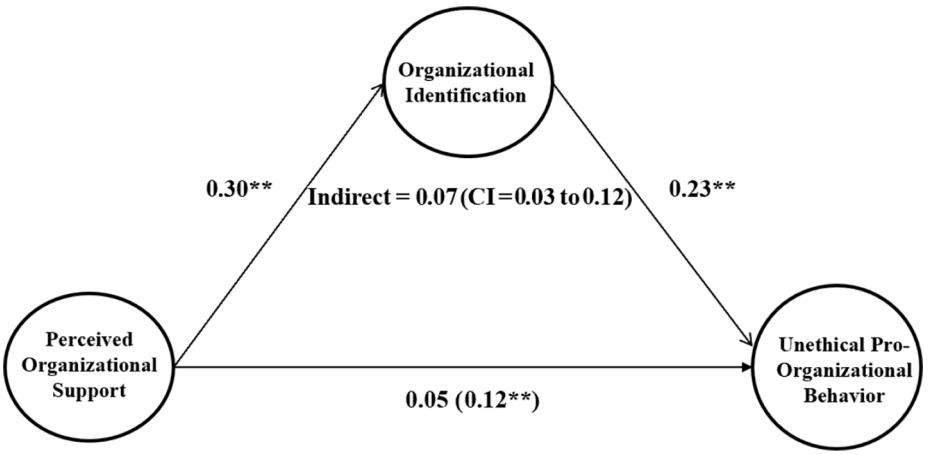


Figure 2.
Mediation model: *Unstandardized regression coefficients shown, *p < 0.05; **p < 0.01, CI: confidence interval*

Variables	B	SE	T	LL 95% CI	UL 95% CI
Gender	0.08	0.44	0.19	−0.78	0.95
Age	−0.06	0.03	−1.99*	−0.13	0.001
Tenure	0.02	0.05	0.42	−0.08	0.12
POS	0.09	0.05	2.17*	0.01	0.19
OID	0.27	0.06	4.24**	0.14	0.39
CSE	−0.18	0.04	−4.79**	−0.26	−0.11
OID × CSE	−0.04	0.01	−2.61**	−0.07	−0.01
R^2			0.15		
F			6.43**		
Conditional effects of organizational identification at different levels of CSE					
	B	*SE*	*T*	*LL 95% CI*	*UL 95% CI*
CSE – 1 SD	*0.45*	*0.13*	*3.36***	*0.19*	*0.72*
CSE mean	*0.22*	*0.09*	*2.22**	*0.02*	*0.41*
CSE + 1 SD	*−0.01*	*0.13*	*−0.09*	*−0.27*	*0.25*
Conditional indirect effect of POS on UPB					
	Effect	*SE*	*LL 95% CI*	*UL 95% CI*	
CSE – 1 SD	0.11	0.023	0.010	0.102	
CSE mean	0.082	0.021	0.043	0.127	

Notes: B: unstandardized regression coefficients; SE: standard error; LL: lower limit, CI: confidence interval, UL: upper limit; *$p < 0.05$; **$p < 0.01$ (OID: organizational identification)

Table 4. Regression results for moderated-mediation model (moderator – CSE)

[0.044, 0.157]). The indirect effect becomes stronger at one standard deviation above (+1 SD) the mean (*indirect effect* = 0.14, 95% CI [0.067, 0.219]) and nonsignificant at one standard deviation below (−1 SD) the mean (*indirect effect* = 0.052, 95% CI [−0.007, 0.126]). These results are in line with *H8*.

Discussion and implications

The rising numbers of ethical scandals which have happened in the recent past have made organizations sit up and take notice of the detrimental effects that unethical behaviors can have on the organizational reputation and business landscape in general. The purpose of this study was to deepen our understanding of UPB by not only investigating its antecedents but also the boundary conditions of their impact.

Supporting the theory of social exchange, the study exhibited that POS was positively and significantly related to UPB. These results challenge conventional notions by showing that the constructs which are considered advantageous for the overall organizational functioning can also lead to unethical behavior by the employees. Additionally, it was seen that the association between POS and UPB was mediated by organizational identification. Therefore, by augmenting and boosting an employees' feeling of identification with the organization, POS enhances the probability of UPB. These results provide support for the theoretical model proposed by Umphress and Bingham (2011).

It was further seen that the influence of organizational identification on UPB was moderated by CSE and positive reciprocity beliefs. CSE acts as a buffer wherein the negative effects of organizational identification on UPB are alleviated for the individuals with high CSE. These results show that even in the wake of high identification with the organization, employees high on CSE keep their ethicality intact. However, reverse is true for positive

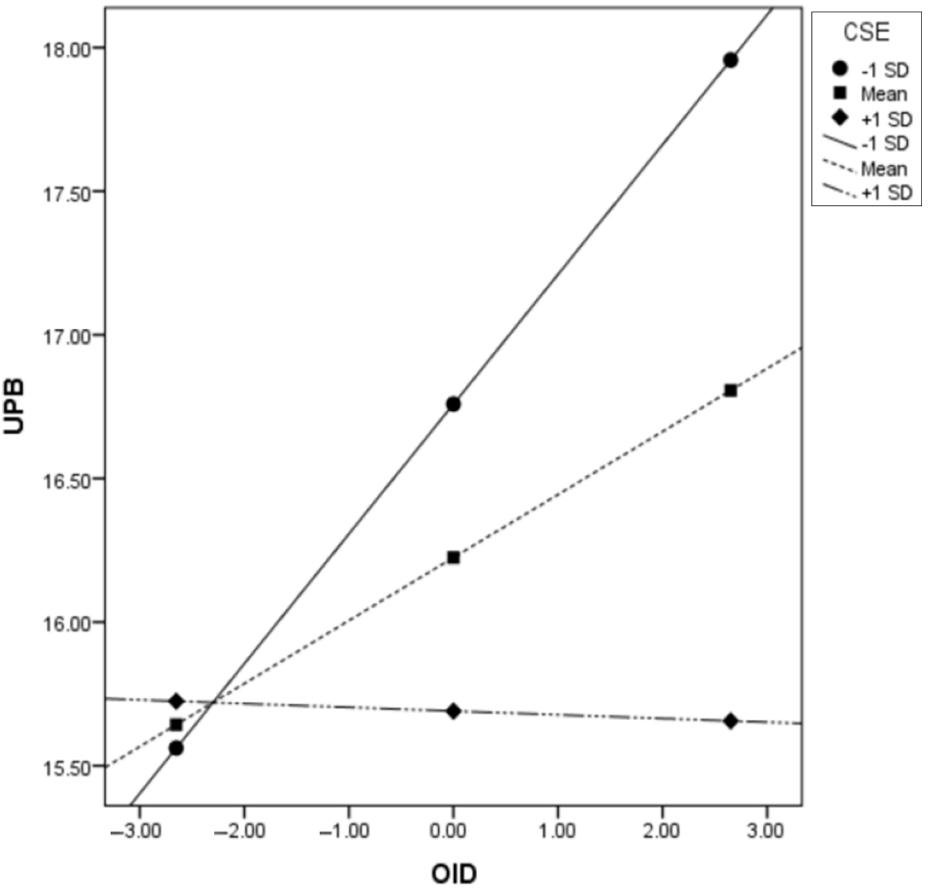


Figure 3.
Interaction of organizational identification and CSE on UPB

reciprocity beliefs which seem to accentuate the relationship between organizational identification and UPB. These findings provide credence to the study conducted by Umphress *et al.* (2010), showing that organizational identification leads to UPB only for the employees high on positive reciprocity beliefs.

Consequently, based on the findings of this study, it may be contended that UPB is impacted jointly by personality and situational factors providing support to the person-situation interactionist approach to UPB (Hattrup and Jackson, 1996). All in all, our theoretically derived hypotheses were strongly supported by the results of the study, which may have many theoretical and practical implications, which are discussed in following sections.

Theoretical implications

As has been noted earlier, majority of research in the area of organizational ethics has been primarily based on the assumption that ethical misconduct in organizations is motivated by individuals' selfish interests with the solitary aim of benefitting self (Thau *et al.*, 2015). Unethical behaviors which are conducted under the pretense of being "proorganizational"

Variables	B	SE	T	LL 95% CI	UL 95% CI
Gender	−0.04	0.45	−0.08	−0.93	0.86
Age	−0.06	0.03	−1.94	−0.13	0.001
Tenure	0.02	0.05	0.30	−0.08	0.12
POS	0.05	0.05	1.12	−0.04	0.14
OID	0.20	0.07	2.96**	0.07	0.33
PRB	0.08	0.04	1.92	−0.002	0.15
OID × PRB	0.02	0.01	2.29*	0.003	0.05
R^2			0.09		
F			3.64**		

Conditional effects of organizational identification at different levels of PRB

	B	***SE***	***T***	***LL 95% CI***	***UL 95% CI***
PRB – 1 SD	0.16	0.09	1.72	−0.02	0.34
PRB mean	0.29	0.08	3.82**	0.14	0.44
PRB + 1 SD	0.43	0.10	4.24**	0.23	0.63

Conditional indirect effect of POS on UPB

	Effect	***SE***	***LL 95% CI***	***UL 95% CI***
PRB – 1 SD	0.052	0.034	−0.007	0.126
PRB mean	0.096	0.029	0.044	0.157
PRB + 1 SD	0.140	0.038	0.067	0.219

Notes: B: unstandardized regression coefficients; SE: standard error; LL: lower limit, CI: confidence interval, UL: upper limit; *$p < 0.05$; **$p < 0.01$; (OID: organizational identification, PRB: positive reciprocity beliefs)

Table 5. Regression results for moderated-mediation model (moderator – PRB)

are especially dangerous because they may be easily ignored by the management but prove exceedingly detrimental for the organization ultimately. However, research dealing with the proorganizational nature of UPB is still in infancy, and the present study adds to the existing literature by using the framework of SET to explore some specific organizational antecedents of such behavior. In doing that, it uncovers the possible negative effects of constructs like POS and OID which are generally considered positive (Cropanzano and Mitchell, 2005).

Second, present research delineates the process through which POS leads to UPB. Our findings suggest that it is not POS *per se* but increased identification with the organization, which comes from the perception of organizational support, that leads to UPB. This may be seen as a pitfall of shifting the employees' perception from individual "I" to shared "We," a process which is otherwise considered positive for facilitating intragroup dynamics (Janssen and Huang, 2008). When employees identify strongly with the organization, societal values and hyper norms become secondary to the interests of the organization. These results support the study by Effelsberg *et al.* (2014), which showed the mediating role of organizational identification in the relationship between transformational leadership, another positive organizational construct and UPB.

Apart from throwing light on the mechanism which links POS to UPB through organizational identification, the research provides details of the boundary conditions for these effects. The present research is an attempt to investigate the dispositional and organizational factors leading to the advent of UPB (e.g. Miao *et al.*, 2013). Our study explored the moderating role of two personality variables, namely, CSE and positive reciprocity beliefs in the relationship between organizational identification and UPB. Both CSE and positive

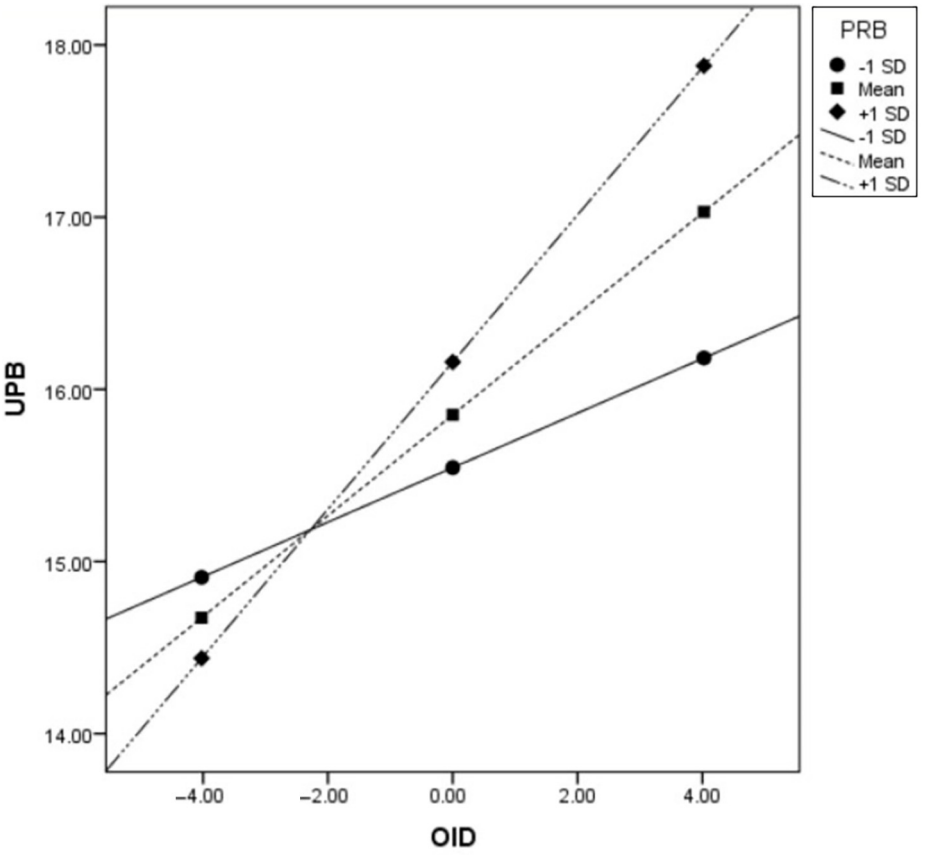


Figure 4.
Interaction of organizational identification and positive reciprocity beliefs on UPB

reciprocity beliefs were seen to moderate the aforesaid relationship giving credence to the assertion that ethical behavior is also a function of personality factors along with situational variables. Taken together, the study advocates the role played by personality variables, along with the organization factors, in explaining UPB. Therefore, this provides a rich theoretical platform for future researchers to study the role of other personality factors that may complement SET in the research on UPB.

Managerial implications

There are obvious real-world implications of this study for managers and organizations. It is important for them to understand what motivates UPB by employees as it will help them reduce and abolish this hazard. Policy enunciations can clearly spell out unacceptable behaviors reinforced by demonstrable action in case of any violations. A clear code of ethics, objective standards and conducive organizational culture can help reduce if not totally eliminate UPB. Research shows that communication of ethical guidelines by managers has a significant impact on reducing unethical behavior by employees (Hassan *et al.*, 2021). Some organizations like the Indian multinational conglomerate TATA have indeed gone the extra mile in this regard by drawing up a comprehensive document, "The Tata Code of Conduct" to

serve as an ethical roadmap for employees and companies. However, care should also be taken in this regard, as too harsh a punishment may deter the employees from engaging in other proorganizational activities.

Second, emphasis should be laid on training and developing the employees to enhance their moral sensitivity through hands-on methods like role-plays, simulation or real-life examples of situations about how to tackle ethical issues in different contexts. Further, counselling services may be provided to guide employees facing ethical dilemmas. However, actions speak louder than words. According to social learning theory (Bandura, 1991), people learn about what is acceptable and unacceptable behavior by watching their role models and through experience. Research indeed shows that ethical values of the supervisors and peers have a large impact on regulation of unethical conduct by the employees (Miao *et al.*, 2020). If top managers are indulging in bribery, making false claims about a product or services in public or inflating their own expense statement, they are sending a signal to other employees that this is acceptable. There is simply no substitute to ethical leadership.

The results of the study show that employees who are high on CSE and have positive self-view are less prone to engage in UPB even when they strongly identify with the organization. Managers should pay more attention to the employees having low CSE as they are more likely to engage in UPB, given their identification with the organization. This may be achieved by constant mentoring and coaching of these employees and trying to monitor them more closely. Additionally, along with other criteria used for making selection decisions, it may be useful for human resource professionals to also take into account the CSE scores of the candidate.

Finally, companies which encourage or even tolerate UPB may face potential harmful consequences through the behavior of customers. Perceived fairness of the organizational practices has been shown to affect the likely behavior of the customers (Fukukawa *et al.*, 2007). If the consumer believes that a company indulges in unethical practices, it can provide rationalization for them to retaliate through unethical and fraudulent behavior toward such an organization. An example can be customers filing inflated claims against an insurance company they believe is not ethical in its practices. Therefore, UPB can be bad for the image and business from both demand and supply side. That's surely food for thought for the top echelons to weigh the downsides of ignoring UPB.

Limitations and scope for future research

This study has some limitations, and we urge the researchers to consider these for their future projects. First, since the research was conducted with self-report measures using single set of participants, the threat of common method bias cannot be totally excluded.

Second, the scope of the study necessitated including only limited number of relevant variables. Using the social exchange perspective, it explored the role of POS in determining the UPB of the employees. Future research in this area may benefit from the identification of other possible social exchange antecedents like positive leader-member exchange and organizational justice which may lead to UPB. Further, the researchers need to identify other dispositional factors which can alleviate the effect of organizational identification on UPB.

Conclusion

In the age of social media and an interconnected globe, the reputation and business of even the largest corporations can be damaged, sometimes fatally, if the public opinion turns against it. The rise in the number of ethical scandals in the recent past and the debilitating cost paid by the concerned businesses make it impossible for the organizations to ignore the threat that UPB poses anymore. The constructs like POS and organizational identification which are considered beneficial for the organizational good can lead to some unintended negative consequences like UPB in absence of proper checks and balances. Additionally, the

employees who exhibit certain personal characteristics are especially susceptible to engage in UPB. In wake of these results, it is suggested that managers should counsel and monitor these individuals more closely. Further, a strong ethical culture and exemplary behavior of the leaders can go a long way in reducing the incidences of UPB.

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